

It provides us with an insight to our world and teaches us virtually everything possible. But then as you would all agree, the weirdest things happen online!

The latest is a site that shows porn, without the act. Termed *PG Porn*, this Web site is aimed at porn fans who enjoy the titillation of porn but are offended by on-screen acts.

It all started when three brothers — James, Sean and Brian Gunn were having a discussion one day. Considering growing acceptance on part of surfers for online porn, they were of the opinion that it holds tremendous commercial scope.

The Gunns are no kids on the block. Sean started in the Emmy Award-winning, Golden Globe-nominated, American comedy-drama series *Gilmore Girls*. His brother James is the screenplay writer of *Scooby Doo* released in 2002.

As James Gunn, writer, director and producer puts it, "This is a place where the porn and the mainstream film industries meet and get to have some understanding of each other. We like to pretend that we're miles and miles away from pornography, but we're not."

According to Frederick Lane, the author of *Obscene Profits: The Entrepreneurs of Pornography in the Cyber Age*, "Pornography's size as an industry is often overstated, but Web-based porn generates at least \$2 billion a year. People are getting more blasé about porn; I don't think there's any question about that. I think the Internet has played a huge role in that, it sort of lowers everybody's threshold."

The name *PG Porn* is taken from the term PG that stands for Parental Guidance

suggested — a rating, at times, given to movies despite being free from objectionable content.

The brothers don't expect you to watch the web-episodes with your parents. Here, comedy replaces sex. They expect most of their viewers to be males, at least initially — they assume most men watch porn.

As a warning, however, Bob Peters, president of New York-based Morality in Media, said *PG Porn* is not as bad as regular porn sites. He worries viewers will eventually move on to the real thing. Without any doubt, it's an open world out there on the Internet, and we need to discern between the good and the bad.

FORBIDDEN FRUIT

Exploring As A Eunuch

For those of you who haven't heard of the Forbidden City, it was the Chinese imperial palace from the mid-Ming Dynasty to the end of the Qing Dynasty. Located in the Dongcheng District, in the heart of Beijing, it now houses the Palace Museum. For nearly 500 years, it was home to the Emperor, his household, and was also the ceremonial and political centre of the Chinese government.

However, after being home to 24 emperors, which includes 14 from the Ming Dynasty, and ten from the Qing Dynasty, the Forbidden City's reign as the political centre of China ended in 1912. This happened with the abduction of Puyi, the last Emperor of China.

Puyi, a lavish man, was held hostage, and



eventually sold precious items to sustain his lifestyle. The rest were stolen by the eunuchs of the palace.

You haven't missed on any of the excitement—IBM has now financed a cultural project to let you visit the Forbidden City, and get a feel of it too. Moreover, it lets you dress up as a eunuch yourself. You can watch emperors from the Qing dynasty dine, train crickets to fight, and then feed them with blood-fattened mosquitoes. Besides, you can also practice archery with a courtesan.

At the virtual palace, launched recently, you can also dress up as part of the imperial entourage.

IBM Program Manager, John Tolva says you can choose among nine historical costumes after entering the virtual City. He adds that you can't run or fly so that other virtual visitors are not distracted.

Named *Beyond Space and Time*, this project also has the finer details such as the eunuchs that shaped the course of the palace, and went on to hold great power. Paula W. Baker, Vice President, IBM says one of the costume you can choose is that of a eunuch.

For those of you who want to get into the finer details, you can also have a closer look at the women who were chosen to serve the emperor.

Built over a period of three years and a whopping \$3 million, by IBM, www.beyondspaceandtime.com is worth trying. We wish

People Who Changed Computing

Dennis Ritchie



Dennis MacAlistair Ritchie wrote the future of computing when he created the C programming language while working for AT&T Bell labs in 1972. One of the first object oriented programming languages, C (and derivatives like C++) is the most commonly used programming language in the world. C is platform independent, is used across a wide variety of architectures and platforms, is one of the most powerful programming languages around, and a number of independent compilers exist.

Dennis Ritchie's contribution to technology does not end there. Along with Ken Thompson, Ritchie developed the Unix operating system. Unix is used as the OS for everything between mobile phones and supercomputers.

In 1983, Ritchie received the Turing award for developing the Unix operating system. In 1999, he received the US National Medal of Technology for Unix. Ritchie was born in New York and achieved a double degree in physics and applied mathematics from Harvard. He retired in 1997.